

SEATTLE

How ICE is using technology, databases to track people

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Under the Trump administration's aggressive deportation agenda, federal immigration agents have been granted an arsenal of surveillance tools to deploy against migrants and citizens.

Immigration and Customs Enforcement and Customs and Border Protection have an array of technologies they have purportedly used to track undocumented migrants, legal immigrants and, in some cases, citizens who oppose the government's intrusion in their local communities.

In Minneapolis, for example, several American citizens were recorded by ICE agents with facial recognition technology, and ICE has used cellphone and social media tools to monitor online activity and potentially hack into phones, The New York Times reported.

The extent to which agents in Washington state are using such technology is not immediately clear.

“They have all these tools, these contracts are active right now,” said Cooper Quintin, a senior staff technologist for the Electronic Frontier Foundation. “So I think it is safe to assume that a lot of this technology is being used.”

The Department of Homeland Security did not respond to a request for comment.

What is in ICE’s toolbelt?

Last year, Trump signed off on increasing the agency’s annual budget from \$8 billion to nearly \$29 billion, making it the highest funded law enforcement agency in the country.

“They bought access to basically every piece of surveillance technology that has been invented in the last 20 years,” Quintin said.

404 Media, an independent technology reporting media organization, has previously reported about a host of newly acquired ICE contracts for surveillance tools, including systems called “Tangles” and “Webloc” that can track cellphones without a warrant.

A contract with Cellebrite helps ICE unlock phones and can easily access all data on the phone, including location history and encrypted app messages. The agency has also resumed a contract with the spyware manufacturer Paragon, which can install malware that reads encrypted messages as they are sent and even turn on a phone’s microphone to record, according to the Electronic

Frontier Foundation. (The Biden administration froze an ICE order with Paragon, an Israeli company, to review whether the spyware could pose a threat to the U.S. government).

ICE has also spent millions to acquire AI tools to scrape social media to surveil people's public accounts. They've also acquired cell-site simulators, or stingrays, which act as cell towers to identify and locate nearby mobile phones. The agency's biometric surveillance tools, which scan faces and irises, have also been deployed in Minnesota. Some citizens have reported having their faces checked in real time by agents using a mobile app, according to The Washington Post.

A new contract with Palantir, Peter Thiel's AI outfit, connects data from different networks and allows ICE to view previously disconnected information about specific people in one place: like immigration and Internal Revenue Service data. 404 Media reported last month that Palantir is working on a tool to map potential "deportation targets," bring up dossiers on them and provide "confidence scores" for the targets' addresses.

Tom Homan, Trump's "border czar" told Fox News last month that the administration would create a "database" of those who protest or impede ICE enforcement.

How are local systems accessed by immigration agents?

A study from the University of Washington Center for Human Rights' Immigrant Rights Observatory found that Flock Safety's automated license plate reader networks data were shared with U.S. Border Patrol by at least eight Washington law enforcement agencies in 2025. Several municipalities have terminated contracts with Flock, which dominates the license plate reader market in the United States, as a result.

Angelina Snodgrass Godoy, the director of the UW Center for Human Rights, said that one of the ways federal officials were able to access data is through a

“side-door search” - when local law enforcement officers conduct a search on behalf of or as a favor to federal immigration officials. “That’s really extraordinarily difficult to track,” she said.

Godoy says the findings fly in the face of the state’s Keep Washington Working Act, which prohibits assistance and information-sharing by local law enforcement with federal immigration authorities. But sometimes, she said, officials have been accessing data without the knowledge of local law enforcement.

“That speaks to a core vulnerability in the systems themselves, and that’s why those surveillance systems are so dangerous, right? Because they are very easy to penetrate,” Godoy said.

Senate Bill 6002, which passed the Washington state Senate last week, would prohibit police from sharing automatic license plate reader data for civil immigration enforcement and require that data be deleted within 21 days unless it’s needed for police evidence.

But there are “many concerns that the bill doesn’t begin to address,” Godoy said, including that it doesn’t affect the many private operators of ALPRs. Godoy’s team found that the Yakima Police Department, for instance, had access to Flock networks operated by more than 90 Lowe’s hardware stores: locations that, like Home Depot, are often the target of enforcement actions.

Another study by the UW researchers found that federal agencies have been able to query a law enforcement data-sharing platform to access Washingtonians’ Department of Licensing data. In November, state officials cut off ICE Enforcement and Removal Operations’ access to the data, but Customs and Border Patrol agents can still query it. Between August and January, the researchers documented 15 cases in which ICE or CBP conducted immigration arrests on Washington roads after querying Department of Licensing data, at

least nine of which were civil immigration arrests, not criminal, according to the study.

“In this market where data is sold and traded with so few restrictions by all these data brokers and surveillance companies, there’s few things that any party has exclusive hold of,” Godoy said. “The DOL has exclusive hold of information.

Godoy said using state licensing data is the only way agents can see a vehicle, know who owns it, look that person up in their other databases, and decide if they want to pull that person over.

What can you do to avoid being surveilled?

Quintin said the most effective way to protect against smartphone surveillance is to not have a phone.

Given that is unrealistic, he said, people should turn their phones off when at a protest or expect to be detained. If you can’t turn off your phone, Quintin recommends putting it in airplane mode. He also recommends people turn off face or fingerprint unlocking options.

To avoid social media monitoring, the foundation suggests people keep accounts private on social media or have their accounts under a pseudonym.

For protesters and demonstrators, wearing a mask is the best option to conceal their identity from facial recognition tech, and bike or take public transit to avoid your license plate info being tracked.

An earlier version of this story misspelled Cooper Quintin’s name.

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